

Answer to the Question No- 2

Antigone vs. Creon

'Antigone' is a Greek play written by Sophocles. It was written in 441 BC. The play is about a story of a young woman, Antigone who defies the order of Creon, the king of Thebes, for burying his dead brother, Polyneices, who was stated as a traitor of the kingdom of Thebes. Antigone's two brother was fighting with each other over the throne of Thebes. One was Eteocles, who was the king of Thebes at that time and another one was Polyneices, who should have been given the throne at that time by his brother Eteocles. They both died in that war. Which resulted Creon's ascending the throne. Creon believed that he was the absolute ruler, and he is not bonded by the laws of God. After becoming the king Creon declared Eteocles a hero, as he was the former king and Polyneices a traitor for attacking the country for power. He gave Eteocles a proper heroic burial but left Polyneices's body to rot and be eaten by dogs and foxes. But Antigone could not take it. Both of them were her brother, one was given this kind of honor and the other one was being dishonored. So she defied the order of the king Creon. She did not care about punishment or the anger of the king she buried the dead body of her brother Polyneices out of love and devotion towards her family. As it was a law of God to bury the dead, so she even risked her life to fulfill the divine laws of the God. Her principle was the God's law is the absolute one and to obey them is must.

Civil disobedience is the of breaking a law to stand up for moral principle (Thoreau, 1849/1993). The action taken by Antigone to bury her one of her dead brother Polyneices is similar to this act. Polyneices attacked Thebes and fought a war with his brother, Eteocles, the

former king of Thebes. When the war was over both of them were dead. Though the next king, Creon buried Eteocles, the former king an honorable burial yet, the king Creon forbids the burial of Polyneices. But Antigone believes that divine law and the unwritten law of God is more important than Creon's. She told Creon, "I did not think your decrees were strong enough to overrule the unwritten, unshakable laws of the God" (Sophocles, trans. 1984, p. 25). This belief of her gave the courage to disobey Creon. Moreover, she was devoted to her family, which was also a reason for her this kind of act. Also, at that time giving proper rituals to the dead was necessary duty, and by doing this Antigone fulfilled her duty toward her family and her God. Though she defied the king's order but followed the order of the absolute ruler, the God. Moreover, she stayed loyal to her family. For these reasons I think the actions of Antigone was legitimate.

When Creon heard about Antigone defying his order and buried her brother, he got angry and wanted to make an example so that no one would think about defying his rules and orders. Creon gave the punishment of being locked in a cave with only foods for few days, so that Antigone would die out of hunger. He did not even think about the perspective of Antigone that why did she did that, what was her motive. Even, his son, Haimon, who was the fiance of Antigone, also told him that his decision was not right and to rethink about all this. But he was blinded by power. Even though, the blind seer, Teiresias, who always knows and tells the truth, warned him about the God's anger, but he thought him as the supreme one, above God's rules. Antigone did not want to accept his dominating and unjust punishment. So killed herself to defy this dominating order. When this happened, Creon faced a tragedy bestowed upon him by the almighty God. His son Haimon killed himself as soon as he heard about the death of Antigone. Not only that, Creon's wife Eurydice, who already had lost her one son, when she heard about her son Haimon death she could not bear the weight of this news and

immediately killed herself. Creon was left all alone. It was all because of his arrogance and false pride. He lost everyone who he called family. Creon's punishment towards Antigone was not just. He was just trying to display his powers and capabilities which backfired himself.

The actions of Antigone was guided by duties and emotions. She was obedient and loyal to her family. She loved her both brothers equally. When one brother's dead body was buried honorably and another brother's body was just left to get rotten, she could not bear it. Out of love and affection she could not ignore this. She took the risk of her life and defy the order of the king Creon to give proper burial to her brother Polyneices. Not only love and fondness to the family was the reason, but she also believed the God was the one above all and his laws were the undeniable one not the laws of a mere human. Moreover, giving proper rituals to the dead, no matter what he has done when he was alive, was the Greek culture of that time. Her risking life and burying her brother shows that how strong her belief to the God and love to her family was and how strong her principle was.

On the contrary, Creon's belief was, the kings are the one who are always above all, even above the laws of God. He gave punishment to Polyneices's dead body as he attacked Thebes. Creon did not try to understand the reason why Polyneices attacked Thebes. Even though Teiresias warned him about God's anger, he did not even flicker. He claimed that he was above the God's laws. Even when he sentenced Antigone punishment, he did not rethought his decision. He told Antigone, "Slaves below everyone, and women below men. But while I am alive, a woman will not rule" (Sophocles, trans. 1984, p. 25). He believed that men are at the upper level than the women in the hierarchy. When Haimon asked his father

and his king, Creon for consideration on Antigone's punishment he insulted and disgraced his son, Haimon. He told Haimon that he (H) was saying this out of love and lust for woman, Antigone and he was saying nonsense.

Antigone's action to bury her brother make an example of fighting for one's right and against unjust laws. She was giving priority to her family and to divine laws more than the laws of the king Creon, a mere human. It shows that how personal belief and bravery can firmly challenge the unjust system and government. On the other hand, king Creon's decisions show the misuse of power. He wanted to make people obey him by violating their rights and by keeping them in the fear of punishments. The punishment he gave to Antigone for disobeying his unjust rule can not be justified in any way. By being stubborn and blinded by power he brought curse upon his family and his own. From the acts of Antigone and Creon we can understand how and when we should switch between personal values and social laws.

Reference:

Sophocles. (1984). *Antigone* (R. Fagles, Trans.). Penguin Classics.

Thoreau, H. D. (1993). *Civil disobedience* (R. Gross, Ed.). Beacon press. (Original work published 1849)